FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Who is an Indian citizen? The question is as old as the Republic itself, and as fraught. For a democracy just 75 years old, born in the trauma of a bloody Partition, the boundaries of belonging have always been both legal and emotional. The latest dotted lines sprang up on June 24, 2025, when the Election Commission of India (ECI) announced its intent to launch a nationwide Special Intensive Revision (SIR) to protect the "integrity of electoral rolls". With Bihar voting in four months, the ECI declared the process would begin there first. While its objective was laudable, the timing and terms were instantly controversial. Especially its insistence on a paper trail that effectively entailed establishing citizenship first. The Opposition dubbed it a backdoor resurrection of the National Register of Citizens (NRC), a project advocated by the Modi government but which collapsed under its own contradictions. The Opposition also accused the ECI of overstepping its constitutional mandate, since citizenship determination falls outside its purview.

Besides the narrow window the ECI left for Bihar's 76.4 million voters to prove their identity, most problematic was the set of 11 documents it originally prescribed as acceptable. These included birth certificates, passports, matriculation certificates, land-ownership papers, or pre-1987 government employment records. Left out were three vital documents commonly used in the past to determine eligibility, which mattered the most to the poor and underprivileged: Aadhaar, voter identity and ration cards. In a state like Bihar, literacy rates in 2025 are still estimated to be less than 75 per cent, and only 65 per cent for women. By some reckonings, almost half of the population is landless. The coverage of birth certificates has been historically low. So, the ECI's stipulations were bound to fail and, in the first round of the exercise, as many as 6.5 million eligible voters did not find their names on the list, forcing the ECI to extend the filing date to September 30.

▲ Jan. 20, 2020

Meanwhile, the debarring of Aadhaar, the biometric-based identity card with near-universal coverage, prompted activists and Opposition leaders to seek legal remedy. A Supreme Court ruling on September 8 finally forced the ECI to accept Aadhaar as a legitimising document. Notably, the SC appended an interesting caveat to its order. It ruled that Aadhaar, though applicable to electoral rolls, would not be proof of citizenship. That circles back to the original problem. India does not have a valid identity proof that establishes citizenship. Outside of the passport that is, which at last count only slightly over 12 per cent of Indians possessed. What we have instead are overlapping and confusing documentation processes relating to the people: the Census, the National Population Register, the voter ID card and Aadhaar. None of them proves citizenship.

This was the gap the Citizen (Amendment) Act (CAA) of 2003 sought to address when it introduced the category of "illegal migrant" as the threshold for exclusion and authorised the Union government to issue a national identity card to all citizens. The NRC was to be an accessory to that, establishing norms of proof within states by birth and descent. But the controversy related to religious exclusion in the updated CAA of 2019 led to nationwide protests. The NRC, meanwhile, had run into a host of practical problems in Assam. Together, that had the effect of stalling the entire exercise.

The theme of citizenship has now been rekindled. In his Independence Day address, Prime Minister Narendra Modi called for a "high-powered demography mission" to weed out illegal immigrants, casting them as a threat to security and livelihood. This comes in a political context where, after Bihar in late 2025, the key states of West Bengal and Assam will go to the polls in 2026. It is no coincidence that they have a high percentage of Muslims, counted at 34 per cent in Assam and 27 per cent in Bengal in 2011. Critics are projecting the two states as battlegrounds where the definition of citizenship will be redrawn in messy ways. The Opposition views a nationwide SIR as a political tool or ruse to eliminate citizens who are likely to vote against the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA), led by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), particularly in these eastern states.

In this week's cover story, Managing Editor Kaushik Deka navigates this complex terrain to distil it down to its essentials. Cross-border flow is a fraught reality. Since identities tend to blur along lines of religion and language, the search for illegal migrants can end up creating fear and uncertainty in entire demographic blocs. Any mass disenfranchisement, even inadvertent, risks igniting social unrest and identity-based political consolidation. Since such a charged atmosphere benefits the BJP, critics allege that this is the actual cause of a nationwide SIR. Having a regime of graded and suspended citizenship, with a new Indian landscape dotted by detention centres for those deemed beyond the pale, could leave a permanent scar on the body politic.

Citizenship is the foundation of democracy. It confers rights, obligations and the power of the vote. To render it uncertain is to imperil the Republic itself. India needs a single, unimpeachable proof of citizenship. Without it, cleansing voter rolls risks creating not clarity, but chaos.

What the country urgently requires is an identity card, not an identity crisis.

(Aroon Purie)